

CENTER-FIRE REVOLVERS

Once revolvers adopted center-fire metallic cartridges (see pp.112–13), invented in the 1860s–70s, several basic designs of frame became established, and these were to remain almost consistent for a very long period. Solid frames with cylinders that hinged out sideways for reloading were most common. The user pushed the extractor rod to eject the cartridges. Alternatives included the Webley and Scott system, which extracted all the cartridges at once as the frame swung open. The strength, simplicity, and durability of a revolver meant that it could be deployed reliably in military, sporting, and self-defense roles. Earlier self-cocking and single-action designs gave way to a more universal use of the double-action mechanism, which provided the option for rapid fire or for cocking the revolver manually to aim with more precision.

▼ RAST AND GASSER M1898

Date 1898

Origin Austria

Barrel 8½in (22.3cm)

Caliber .32in

This solid-frame, double-action pistol was issued to soldiers in the Austro-Hungarian Army in World War I. Around 200,000 of them were produced from 1898 to 1912. In this design, the cylinder revolved around a fixed axle and cartridges were loaded and extracted one at a time through a rearward-hinging gate.



► COLT NEW SERVICE

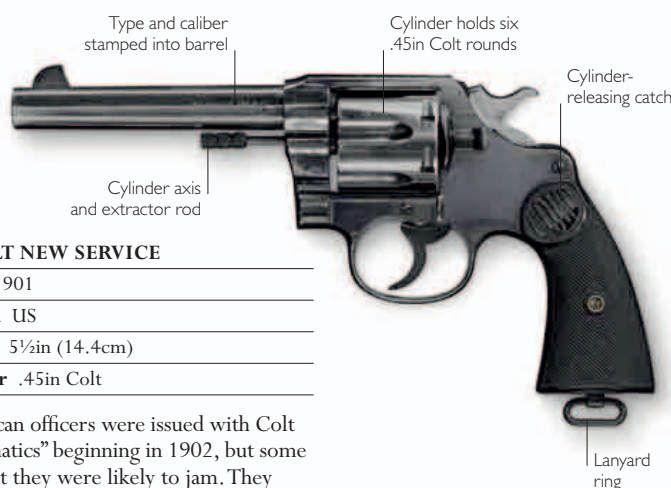
Date 1901

Origin US

Barrel 5½in (14.4cm)

Caliber .45in Colt

American officers were issued with Colt “automatics” beginning in 1902, but some felt that they were likely to jam. They preferred the last revolver produced for the US Army—the .45in-caliber double-action Colt New Service, which remained in service until 1941.



▲ LEBEL MODÈLE 1892

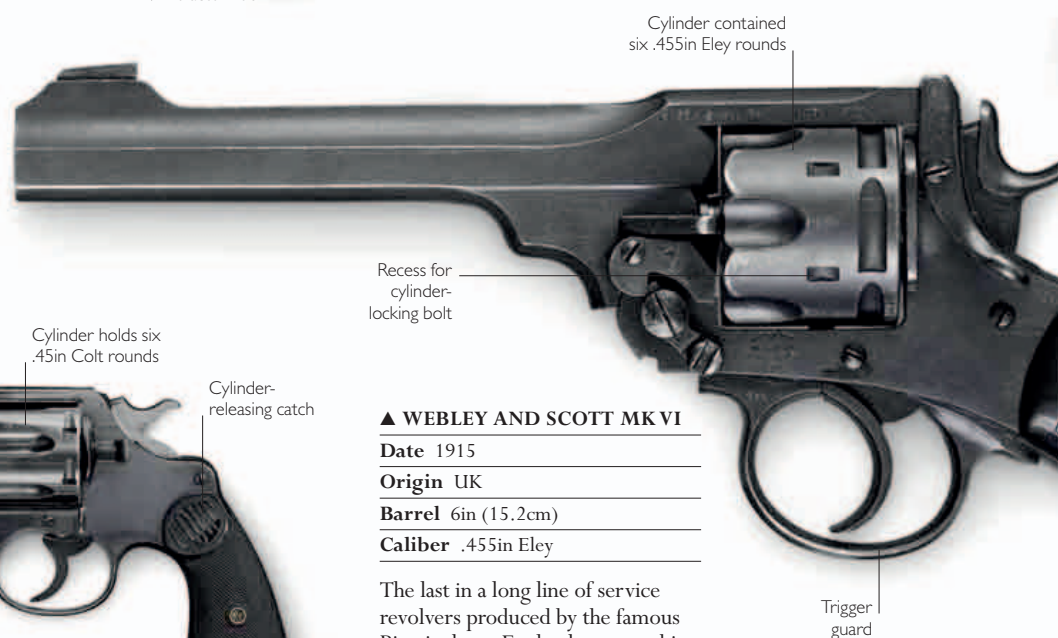
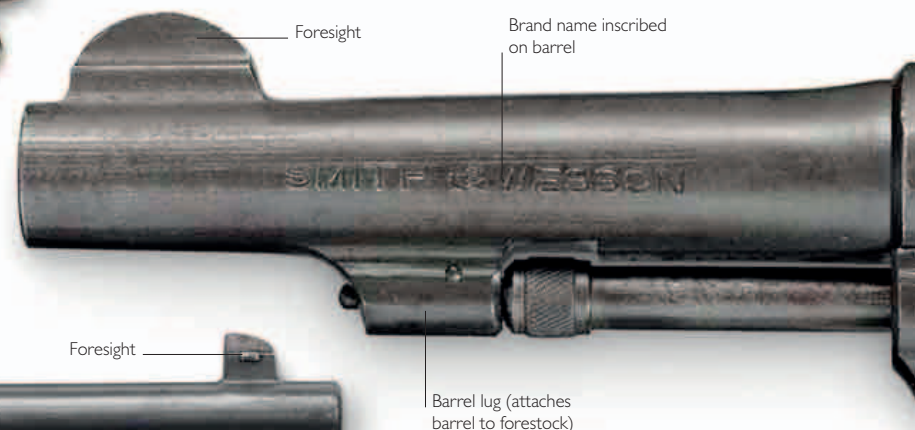
Date 1892

Origin France

Barrel 11¼in (28.6cm)

Caliber 8 × 27mm rim-fire

The double-action, solid-frame Lebel Modèle 1892 was loaded by means of a gate. It was used by the French Army in World War I.



▲ WEBLEY AND SCOTT MK VI

Date 1915

Origin UK

Barrel 6in (15.2cm)

Caliber .455in Eley

The last in a long line of service revolvers produced by the famous Birmingham, England, partnership, the Mark VI was introduced early in World War I. This revolver, which took Eley cartridges, was renowned for its sturdy reliability. Its frame could hinge open to expose the rear face of the cylinder for rapid reloading.